

week by Penguin Random House (PRH), a company currently involved in a stand-off with Waterstones.

[2]①The problem began late last year, when PRH confirmed that it had introduced a credit limit with Waterstones “at a very significant level”. ②The trade magazine *The Bookseller* reported that Waterstones branch managers were being told to remove PRH books from prominent areas such as tables, display spaces and windows, and were “quietly retiring them to their relevant sections”.

[3]①PRH declined to comment on the issue, but a spokesperson for Waterstones told me: “Waterstones are currently operating with reduced credit terms from PRH, the only publisher in the UK to place any limitations on our ability to trade. ②We are not boycotting PRH titles but we are doing our utmost to ensure that availability for customers remains good despite the lower overall levels of stock. ③We are hopeful with our shops now open again that normality will return and that we will be allowed to buy appropriately. ④Certainly, our shops are exceptionally busy. ⑤The sales for our May Books of the Month surpassed any month since 2018.”

[4]①In the meantime, PRH authors have been the losers. ②Big-name PRH authors may suffer a bit, but it's those mid-list authors, who normally rely on Waterstones staff's passion for promoting books by lesser-known writers, who will be praying for an end to the dispute.

[5]①It comes at a time when authors are already worried about the consequences of the proposed merger between PRH and another big publisher, Simon & Schuster—the reduction in the number of unaligned UK publishers is likely to lead to fewer bidding wars, lower advances, and more conformity in terms of what is published.

[6]①“This is all part of a wider change towards concentration of power and cartels. ②Literary agencies are getting bigger to have the clout to negotiate better terms with publishers, publishers consolidating to deal with Amazon,” says Lownie. ③“The publishing industry talks about diversity in terms of authors and staff but it also needs a plurality of ways of delivering intellectual contact, choice and different voices. ④After all, many of the most interesting books in recent years have come from small publishers.”

[7]①We shall see whether that plurality is a casualty of the current need among publishers to be big enough to take on all-comers.

书屋 (PRH) 出版, 该公司目前与水石书店陷入了僵局。

(32) 这个问题始于去年年底, 当时企鹅兰登书屋证实已经对水石书店实行了“水平十分显著的”信贷限额。行业杂志《书商》报道称, 水石书店的分店经理被告知要把企鹅兰登书屋出版的书籍从桌子、展示区和橱窗等显眼区域移走, 并“悄悄地将这些书放回相关区域”。

(33) 企鹅兰登书屋拒绝就此事发表评论, 但是水石书店的一位发言人告诉我: “目前水石书店是在企鹅兰登书屋缩短了信贷期限的情况下经营的, 企鹅兰登书屋是英国唯一一家对我们的交易能力施加限制的出版商。我们没有抵制企鹅兰登书屋出版的书籍, 而是在尽力确保对顾客的供应仍然处于良好状态, 尽管总体库存水平较低。现在我们的书店已经重新开张了, 我们希望可以恢复正常, 并且我们可以获准适当地购买书籍。当然, 我们的书店特别忙。(33) 我们5月份的月度图书销量超过了2018年以来的任何一个月的图书销量。”

在此期间, 企鹅兰登书屋的作家沦为这场冲突中的受害者。(34) 知名的企鹅兰登书屋作家可能会受到一些影响, 但会祈祷这场纷争结束的还是那些书刊销量排行居中的作家, 他们通常依赖水石书店员工的热情来推销知名度较低的作家的作品。

(35) 与此同时, 作家们已经在担心企鹅兰登书屋和另一家大型出版商西蒙与舒斯特拟议合并的后果——未联盟的英国出版商数量下降很可能导致更少的竞拍战、更低的预付款以及更一致的出版内容。

(35) “这都是向着权力集中和企业联盟发生的更广泛变化的一部分。文学机构正变得越来越大, 以便获得影响力与出版商定更有利的条件, 而出版商正合并起来以应对亚马逊,” 劳尼表示。(35) “出版业从作家和员工的角度谈论多样性, 但它也需要多种方式来传递知识联系、选择和不同的声音。毕竟, 近年来许多最有趣的书都来自小型出版商。”

当前, 出版商有着需要大到足以对付所有竞争者的需求, 至于这种多元性是否会成为这一需求的牺牲品, 让我们拭目以待。